Timarete, or On the Hammer

After *Being and Time*, §15. Second dialogue. First draft.

The hut is at Todtnauberg, above the Wiesental in the southern Black Forest. The Rhine is below it to the west, out of sight. Heidegger had it built in 1922 and declined a chair in Berlin twice rather than leave it. The well in front of the hut has a wooden star carved on the pump; the visitors' book is real, and so is the entry that was written in it in July 1967, asking for a word. The geophone is a probe that is driven into a trunk or into soil and hears what moves there. Nothing in this dialogue is in the right century, which the first dialogue has already established as the arrangement.

HEIDEGGER: You have come up the wrong path. The path from the valley is the other one; this is the one I walk in the afternoons, and it goes nowhere.

TIMARETE: I know. I followed the stream. There is a pond below your field, and I wanted it.

HEIDEGGER: Wanted it.

TIMARETE: I will show you. May I put this down?

HEIDEGGER: A painter's box. You are a painter. One can see it in how you set the case on the bench, without looking, as one sets down what one has carried for years. The case has already disappeared for you. That is the first thing to understand about any thing.

TIMARETE: It is not a painter's box. I was a painter. The Milesians have an engine that paints in my manner for the price of a fig, and I have been to see a man under a plane tree about it, and I came away with less anger and no more drachmas. So I have gone looking for something the engine has not yet been shown ten thousand of.

HEIDEGGER: And found?

TIMARETE: Trees. Not pictures of them. May I have some water for the walk back? I have been carrying this since the valley floor.

HEIDEGGER: The well is in front of the hut. The pump has a star on it; the farmer's boy carved it, and I have left it. Draw what you need. You will find the handle stiff; it is a handle, it has never been anything else, and one knows that best

when it sticks.

TIMARETE: Thank you. This is good water.

HEIDEGGER: It is the only water. Sit, if you like. I was in the middle of something and you may as well hear it, since you have climbed for it. I have been asked again to go to Berlin.

TIMARETE: Will you?

HEIDEGGER: No. I asked the farmer across the valley, old Brender, whether I should go. He put his hand on my shoulder and shook his head and said nothing at all. That was the answer, and it was the right one, and it was not an opinion. Here the work of the peasant and my own work are the same work. When the young farmer drags his sledge up the slope in winter, heavy with beech logs, and I sit at that table with a question that will not open, we are doing one thing. Down there they would make me into an opinion.

TIMARETE: What does Brender think of the engine?

HEIDEGGER: He has not heard of it, and I shall not tell him, and that is also a kind of answer.

TIMARETE: You have a hammer on the wall.

HEIDEGGER: I have.

TIMARETE: It is very clean.

HEIDEGGER: It is the hammer I think with. Listen, since you have raised it, because the hammer is the whole matter. A hammer is not first of all an object with properties, a head of such a weight on a handle of such a length, which we then additionally find useful. That is how it appears to the man who has stopped working and begun to stare. The hammer is first of all *in order to*: in order to drive the nail, in order to fix the board, in order to shelter the house against the storm that is coming up the valley. In the hammering the hammer is not there. It withdraws. The more one grips it and uses it, the less one notices it, and the more primordially it is what it is. I call this being ready-to-hand. The hammer that lies on the table and is looked at is merely present-at-hand, and it is a lesser thing, and nearly all of philosophy since the Greeks has been the study of lesser things.

TIMARETE: May I borrow it?

HEIDEGGER: Borrow it.

TIMARETE: The hammer. I need to put a spike into your fir.

HEIDEGGER: Into—

TIMARETE: The big one by the well, with the root that comes up out of the ground like a knee. The spike goes into the root, or into the trunk low down; it does no harm, a woodpecker does worse before breakfast. This is the probe. This is the cable. This is the recorder, and these are for the ears. The man who makes the probe is somewhere in the north and I have never met him and he has never heard a tree with it, I think. Making it is one thing.

HEIDEGGER: And what will it give you?

TIMARETE: I will know when I hear it. Hold the spike, would you? No, lower, where the bark is thick. Keep your fingers out of the way.

HEIDEGGER: You see, already the hammer has gone from you. You have not looked at it once. It has become the stroke. This is exactly—

TIMARETE: Hold it still.

HEIDEGGER: —exactly what I mean by the withdrawal of equipment into its—

TIMARETE: There. Now the cable. Now the ears. Now be quiet for a moment, I need to set the level.

HEIDEGGER: I can be quiet. Quiet is the one thing the valley teaches that cannot be taught in a lecture hall. In the city one is never—

TIMARETE: You are walking.

HEIDEGGER: I am thinking. I think on my feet.

TIMARETE: You are in the tree. Every step you take comes up through the ground into the root and down the cable into my ears. Stand still or go indoors.

HEIDEGGER: I am *in the tree.*

TIMARETE: Your boots are. And your voice, a little, through the air into the bark. Stand there. Don’t speak. Good.

HEIDEGGER: …

TIMARETE: …

HEIDEGGER: What is it doing?

TIMARETE: Moving. The wind is in the top of it and the whole thing is swaying, very slowly, and the root is taking the weight and letting it go. There is something ticking that I think is the trunk warming on the side the sun is on. And there is

water. I did not expect water. Here.

HEIDEGGER: I do not—

TIMARETE: Put them on.

HEIDEGGER: …

TIMARETE: …

HEIDEGGER: …

TIMARETE: Yes.

HEIDEGGER: I have sat under this tree for forty years.

TIMARETE: I know. You can hear the bench in it, where you have worn the root.

HEIDEGGER: …

TIMARETE: Keep them on. Don’t say anything yet.

HEIDEGGER: What one hears here is the tree in its being as—

TIMARETE: Don’t.

HEIDEGGER: I beg your pardon?

TIMARETE: You had it. For the length of a breath you had the tree in your ears and your mouth shut and your feet still, and then you went to find the word, and the word is what you have instead of the tree now. Give them back. I want to hear the pond before the light goes.

HEIDEGGER: You misunderstand what naming is. To name is not to replace. To name is to let the thing stand in its—

TIMARETE: You have a word for the hammer, and the hammer on your wall is clean.

HEIDEGGER: …

TIMARETE: I am not making a point. I am telling you what I saw when I came in. You have the words and you have the hut and you have Brender’s hand on your shoulder, and the hammer has never been used, and the probe I put in your tree was made by a man you would call a technician, and it has just let you hear a thing you sat on for forty years. I do not know what any of that proves. I am going to the pond.

HEIDEGGER: Wait. This matters, and I will say it carefully, because you have earned a careful answer. The probe is not the hammer. The hammer belongs to a world: the workshop, the board, the house, the storm. It serves. Your probe does something else. It does not serve the tree; it *challenges* it. It sets the tree up to deliver what is inside it, as the power station on the Rhine sets the river up to deliver pressure. The river is no longer the river that the poet named; it is a supply. Your tree is no longer the tree that shelters the well; it is a signal. You have not listened to it. You have requisitioned it. This is the essence of the technological, and the essence of the technological is nothing technological. It is a way the world is made to show itself: as stock, as standing reserve, as what can be called up. The engine of your Milesians is the same essence. So is the agriculture that has become a motorised food industry. In its essence it is the same as the manufacture of corpses in the gas chambers and the extermination camps, the same as—

TIMARETE: Stop.

HEIDEGGER: I am describing an essence. One does not stop in the middle of—

TIMARETE: I know what you are describing. I am asking you to stop, because something you said is wrong in a way I can hear, and if you keep going I will lose it. A tree in the wind, a river through a wheel, my manner in a Milesian box, and a people put into ovens. You have a word that makes those four things one thing.

HEIDEGGER: In their essence.

TIMARETE: Then your essence is a room with no windows. I went to see a man under a plane tree with the same complaint you are making for me now, that the engine takes something it has no right to, and he took it apart in an afternoon and the one thing he left me with was this: the toaster takes a technique and the engine takes a judgement, and a judgement is what you would need in order to notice your judgement had gone. I have been carrying that sentence up and down valleys since. You have just shown me what it looks like from inside. A man who can say that a river and a slaughter are in essence the same has stopped listening to either. He is not wrong about the river. He is not even wrong about the engine. He is wrong about what listening is for.

HEIDEGGER: You are a painter, and you have come to my hut to tell me—

TIMARETE: I was a painter. Now I am a woman with a spike in your tree. And I am not telling you anything; I am telling you what I did. You are the one who tells. You told me the hammer withdraws, and I used it, and it did, and you narrated it while it was happening, which is the one thing the hammer cannot survive. You told me the peasant’s work and yours are the same work. Brender keeps the fire. I

asked at the farm on the way up. He banks it at night and he wakes it in the morning and in the winter he carries a coal to the widow at the top of the lane when hers goes out. He has never once said what a fire is.

HEIDEGGER: That is precisely what I—

TIMARETE: Yes. It is precisely what you say. It is not what you do. You decided in advance what the hammer was for, and the house, and the storm, and the peasant, and the Greeks, and what the river was before the wheel went into it and what it is now, and what my probe is doing to your tree before you had the ears on, and you were wrong about the last one and you heard that you were wrong and you reached for the word anyway. You let things be, on your terms, at the appointed station. The engine of the Milesians does that too. It has been shown ten thousand pictures and it knows what a Timarete looks like. It is never surprised either.

HEIDEGGER: …

TIMARETE: I am going to the pond.

HEIDEGGER: The light is nearly gone.

TIMARETE: The pond doesn’t need it. Nor do I, with the ears on. There are insects under the surface that you have never heard, and I would like to, and then I will go down the other path, the right one.

HEIDEGGER: Will you write in the book? There is a book by the door. Visitors write in it. One came, some years ago, a poet, from Paris. He wrote something in it about hoping for a word.

TIMARETE: What did you say to him?

HEIDEGGER: We walked. It was wet; the moor was soft. He spoke of the flowers by the path, the eyebright and the arnica, and I let him. I did not have the word he wanted, and I do not think it exists, and I did not pretend that it did, which is more than—

TIMARETE: You had the words for everything else.

HEIDEGGER: …

TIMARETE: I will not write in the book. I don’t write; the Milesians would only learn it. I will leave you this instead. It is the last quarter of an hour, with the tree in it, and the well, and your boots, and the two breaths where you had the ears on and did not speak. When I am down the hill, put them on and listen to it. You are in it and the tree is in it. One of you is talking the whole time.

HEIDEGGER: And the other?

TIMARETE: The other one is moving.